50 Questions to Preserve a Life Story

A personal-history interview guide with fictional sample answers. Designed to help families preserve memories, personality, relationships, values, and life experiences for future generations. All answers are illustrative and should be replaced with the person's own words.

Early Life & Family

1. Where and when were you born?

Sample answer: I was born in 1958 in a small coastal town.

2. What was your childhood home like?

Sample answer: It was a modest house full of cousins, conversation, and the smell of fresh bread.

3. Who raised you, and what were they like?

Sample answer: My parents raised me. My mother was patient, and my father believed in keeping promises.

4. What is your earliest clear memory?

Sample answer: I remember running barefoot after a summer rain when I was about four.

5. What family traditions mattered most to you?

Sample answer: Every Friday we ate together, even when money was tight.

6. Who were your siblings, and how did you get along?

Sample answer: I had two sisters and one brother. We argued often but always protected one another.

7. What stories did your grandparents tell you?

Sample answer: My grandfather told stories about traveling for work and helping strangers along the way.

8. What was the hardest part of growing up?

Sample answer: Moving away from my friends when I was twelve was very difficult.

9. What childhood moment still makes you smile?

Sample answer: My brother and I built a kite that flew for almost an hour.

10. What values did your family teach you?

Sample answer: Be generous, tell the truth, and never look down on anyone.

Education, Work & Turning Points

11. What did you enjoy learning as a child?

Sample answer: I loved mathematics and understanding how machines worked.

12. Who was a teacher or mentor who changed your life?

Sample answer: My science teacher encouraged me to apply for university.

13. What did you study, and why?

Sample answer: I studied engineering because I wanted to solve practical problems.

14. What was your first job?

Sample answer: I repaired radios in a small shop during school holidays.

15. What work are you most proud of?

Sample answer: I helped build a reliable water system for a rural community.

16. What was your biggest professional setback?

Sample answer: I lost a business opportunity after trusting the wrong partner.

17. How did you make an important life decision?

Sample answer: I spoke to people I trusted, then chose the path I could live with.

18. What risk are you glad you took?

Sample answer: I moved to another city for a job when I knew almost no one.

19. What accomplishment meant the most to you?

Sample answer: Seeing my children become kind, independent adults.

20. If you could revisit one turning point, what would it be?

Sample answer: I would spend more time with my father before he passed away.

Love, Relationships & Community

21. How did you meet your closest friend?

Sample answer: We met on the first day of university and stayed close for decades.

22. How did you meet your spouse or an important partner?

Sample answer: We met at a family gathering and talked for hours about books.

23. What did love mean to you?

Sample answer: Love meant showing up, especially when life was inconvenient.

24. What did you learn from being a parent or caregiver?

Sample answer: Listening is often more helpful than giving advice.

25. Who helped you during your hardest years?

Sample answer: My sister called me every week and never let me feel alone.

26. What did you most enjoy doing with friends?

Sample answer: Long evening walks followed by tea and laughter.

27. How did you try to support your community?

Sample answer: I volunteered to tutor students who could not afford extra lessons.

28. Was there someone you wished you had thanked?

Sample answer: I wish I had properly thanked my first supervisor for believing in me.

29. How did you handle disagreements with people you loved?

Sample answer: I tried to apologize quickly and discuss the issue when we were calm.

30. What do you hope loved ones remember about you?

Sample answer: That they felt safe, respected, and welcome around me.

Personality, Beliefs & Everyday Life

31. How would you describe yourself in three words?

Sample answer: Curious, stubborn, and loyal.

32. What made you laugh the most?

Sample answer: Unexpected jokes from children and my own terrible puns.

33. What were your favorite foods and why?

Sample answer: Homemade rice and fish reminded me of family gatherings.

34. What music, books, or films stayed with you?

Sample answer: Old songs my mother played and stories about ordinary people doing brave things.

35. What did an ideal ordinary day look like?

Sample answer: A quiet morning, meaningful work, lunch with family, and a sunset walk.

36. What hobbies gave you joy?

Sample answer: Gardening, fixing broken appliances, and taking photographs.

37. What places felt most like home?

Sample answer: The courtyard of my childhood house and the kitchen in our family home.

38. Did faith, spirituality, or a philosophy guide your life?

Sample answer: My faith taught me gratitude, humility, and responsibility toward others.

39. What personal habit are you glad you developed?

Sample answer: Writing a few lines in a notebook at the end of each day.

40. What is something people often misunderstood about you?

Sample answer: My quietness sometimes looked like disinterest, but I was usually listening carefully.

Lessons, Memories & Legacy

41. What was the happiest period of your life?

Sample answer: The years when our children were young and the house was full of noise.

42. What was your most difficult loss, and how did it change you?

Sample answer: Losing my mother taught me not to postpone important conversations.

43. What mistake taught you the most?

Sample answer: I once put work before family for too long, and I learned to protect my time.

44. What advice would you give your younger self?

Sample answer: Do not confuse being busy with living well.

45. What important historical or social change did you witness?

Sample answer: I watched computers transform how people learned, worked, and stayed connected.

46. What story about your life do you want future generations to hear?

Sample answer: When I had little money, a stranger helped me travel home. I tried to repay that kindness to others.

47. What beliefs or opinions changed as you grew older?

Sample answer: I became less concerned with winning arguments and more interested in understanding people.

48. What are you grateful for that you rarely mentioned?

Sample answer: The people who helped me quietly without expecting anything in return.

49. What message would you leave for your family and future generations?

Sample answer: Take care of one another, keep learning, and make time for ordinary joys.

50. How would you like your life to be remembered in one sentence?

Sample answer: I tried to leave people and places a little better than I found them.